

the stuff legends speak of! Character customisation is good, and there are many classes to choose from. Once again, you cannot increase stats like in a regular RPG, but only by actually performing actions that utilise those stats repeatedly—thereby improving them over time. For example, as a fighter, if you use a lot of swords in a melee, your blade skill will keep on increasing the more baddies you slash up. Also, the more you block attacks, the more your block skill will improve. This is a unique experience and actually works quite well in the game. Combat—whether melee, or ranged or magical—works well, and the spell effects are particularly spectacular. Even the in-game physics is superb—you can actually shoot an arrow at an unsuspecting enemy and watch his body being plucked by the impact, turned around and thrown in a heap: very realistic. It's so pleasurable to see one of your flame spells incinerating someone while he runs around in panic! *Oblivion's* combat system rewards you every time you score a hit by actually making you feel like it. Likewise, when you're getting thrashed, your vision will blur and sway with the impact—thereby throwing off your aim.

The open-endedness of this game is sheer genius; there's no hurry to complete quests. In fact, you can take as long as you like, exploring the world around you—the fields, the sprawling meadows, the underground caverns, the

towns, and the like. If you're in a hurry, though, you can rush around and complete quests. Then there are guilds to join, bounties to collect, people to interact with, weapons to maintain—all vying for some of your time. *Oblivion* also allows you to buy a horse to speed up your excursions, and you can gallop off to quests, instead of plodding along! All in all, while *Oblivion* plays slowly for the first hour or so, once you get a few completed quests under your belt and a couple of level-ups.

What gets slightly repetitive, though, is the constant need to travel around from quest to quest, although you can use the map travel system that instantly teleports you to your destination. The actual time spent simply moving around exploring does tend to add up though, and you find yourself actually waiting for some action. We're not sure whether the waiting is bad, or if the anticipation it creates is good—you decide!

My Verdict

Oblivion is an excellent game if you're a fan of the genre—and perhaps even if you aren't. Definitely one of the most anticipated games of 2006, it has delivered with aplomb: I was completely hooked. The only caveat is that *Oblivion* requires CPU and rendering power, and makes no bones about this. A lot of the gameplay is in its visual element, and if you have a more-than-decent rig, this game is an absolute must-have. ■

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I shoot, I score



Giddy up!



The Imperial City walkway

Rating: 8/10 Price: Rs 2,999
Developer: Bethesda Game Studios
Publisher: 2K Games
Web site: www.bethsoft.com
Distributor: e-XPRESS Interactive
Minimum System Requirements:
512 MB system RAM, 2 GHz P4 or equivalent, 4.6 GB HDD space, DirectX 9.0c (included), 128 MB Direct3D Compatible video card and DirectX 9.0 compatible driver, DirectX 8.1 compatible sound card

